Grandpa

By Mary Krell-Oishi

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *When a loved one is diagnosed with Alzheimer's disease, the effects on the family can be overwhelming.*
ACTRESS 2: *The reality that someone you love has such a devastating illness can trigger a range of emotions — including fear, sadness, confusion and anger.*
ACTRESS 1: *Conflicts are common as family members struggle to deal with the situation.*
ACTRESS 2: *In this selection Kathy and her younger sister Julia struggle to understand each other and the process.*
TOGETHER: *Grandpa by Mary Krell-Oishi*

KATHY: **(Pgs 167-176)** Julia, is Mom home yet?

JULIA: Not yet.

KATHY: Did she say when she'd get home?

JULIA: Nope.

KATHY: Great. Have you started dinner?

JULIA: No. Was I supposed to? No one told me.

KATHY: Just once it would be really nice if you did something without having to be told.

JULIA: *(a beat)* Yeah. OK.

KATHY: You are something else, you know that? Did you at least clean up the dishes?

JULIA: No, Kathy, I didn't clean up the dishes.

KATHY: Good grief, you are beyond belief.

JULIA: I'll do it, OK. I was planning on doing it later. Not everything has to be done on some mythical schedule you've decided on.

KATHY: Well, please, -don't put yourself out. God forbid that you might actually help out around here without having to be told. Forget it. I'll take care of them. God knows I take care of everything else around here lately.

JULIA: Martyr mode. Good.

KATHY: And just what does that mean?

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JULIA: Just that you're at your happiest when you can do it all and make sure that everyone knows you're the one doing it.

KATHY: Someone's got to follow through around here. It's for sure that it isn't going to be you.

JULIA: Fine! You want them done now, I'll do them now!

KATHY: Good! Do it!

JULIA: What are you going to do?

KATHY: Well, I can assume that there is still laundry sitting on the washer that has yet to be done, the carpets need vacuuming, and dinner needs to be started. So, I guess that will keep me busy, unless, of course, you managed to take care of at least some of the chores. *(No response from JULIA)* Just as I thought.

JULIA: I said I'd take care of the dishes for you.

KATHY: What do you mean for me? You are not doing me any favors, you know. Why, all of a sudden, are you thinking you're doing the dishes for me?

JULIA: Forget it. *(begins to exit)*

KATHY: And clean up your crap from the room.

JULIA: Why don't you quit telling me what to do?

KATHY: Because if I don't, nothing gets done. And Mom doesn't need to come home to the house looking like this.

JULIA: She won't even notice.

KATHY: The hell she won't.

JULIA: She doesn't notice anything anymore. We could not even be here and she wouldn't miss us.

KATHY: For once in your life, quit thinking about yourself and think about someone else. Mom is going through enough right now without you throwing your attitude at her.

JULIA: I don't know why she has to be at the hospital all the time.

KATHY: Because her father is dying. Grandpa is dying.

JULIA: He's been dying. Why doesn't he get it over with?

KATHY: *(a beat)* I can't believe you just said that.

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JULIA: *(quietly)* Well, I did. And I mean it, too.

KATHY: I have never in my life heard anything so awful come out of your mouth. I've known you to be unbelievably selfish, self-centered and wrapped up completely in your own needs, but this is out of control, even for you.

JULIA: Why is it selfish? Honestly, why? He's going to die anyway, isn't he?

KATHY: He's had bad times before and pulled out of them. He'll pull out of this one, too.

JULIA: Take off the rose-colored glasses, Kathy. Join the real world. Grandpa is dying. He's been sick for a long time and dying a little bit more everyday. He's done nothing but get worse.

KATHY: He has good days.

JULIA: When? When was the last good day he had? A year ago? Maybe longer?

KATHY: How would you know? When was the last time you went to see him?

JULIA: What's the point? He doesn't even remember who we are anymore.

KATHY: He does too remember. Maybe not our names, but he knows we are family. His eyes light up when we come in the room and hug him.

JULIA: His eyes light up whenever anyone walks in the room and gives him a hug. He's a friendly guy. However, whether you want to accept this or not, he has no idea who we are.

KATHY: You are so cold.

JULIA: No, I'm not. I'm realistic. I've watched Grandpa shuffling around, looking at all of us without really knowing who we are, unable to complete a coherent sentence, and then I watch Mom get sadder and sadder. There is no point to this.

KATHY: God does not give us more than we can bear. What does not kill us makes us stronger.

JULIA: Well, I feel better now. Cliches sure can brighten up a cloudy day. Why don't you tell Mom that when she comes back from watching her father deteriorate into an empty shell.

KATHY: *(looks at JULIA for a moment, then quietly)* I have things to take care of.

JULIA: Yes, do what you always do. Walk away from reality. For God's sake, don't face what is happening.

KATHY: Oh, be like you? Wish Grandpa right into his grave.

JULIA: If you had any compassion, you would.

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KATHY: Compassion? You talk to me about compassion? Who makes sure things are taken care of? Not you. Who tries to comfort Mom when she feels down about everything that is going on? Not you. Who goes to visit Grandpa in the home? Not you.

JULIA: I do my share, dammit. Maybe I'm not as vigilant about dusting the nooks and crannies of this house, but I do help out. And I do try to talk to Mom, but it's hard.

KATHY: And visiting Grandpa? What about that?

JULIA: I can't. I just can't. It's too hard to take.

KATHY: Ah, here we go. Now we're getting down to it. It's too hard to take for poor little Julia. Never mind the times he was there for you. Let's just forget all about that. Forget about the Disneyland trips, the donut hunts, dancing at parties, basketball games. Let's just forget everything we ever did with Grandpa and take care of ourselves. That is just so typical of you.

JULIA: You don't get it, do you? Don't you see that those are the memories I want to keep alive? I want to remember that man that I loved, that I looked up to, the way he was then, not the way he is right now. I don't even know this person.

KATHY: Well, you better try to know him while there's still time to do so.

JULIA: That's just it. There is no time anymore. I didn't tell you this, but I did go down to see him about a month ago. I went down to the home after school one day to see how he was. It had been a long time, at least a couple months since I'd been down there. You know what he did? He looked at me. No, he looked through me.

KATHY: Did you tell him who you were?

JULIA: I shouldn't have to tell him who I am. I'm his granddaughter for God's sake. He was in the delivery room when I was born. He should know who I am.

KATHY: He can't help what is happening to him.

JULIA: I know that, I'm not stupid. But it gets worse. I stayed for just a few minutes, and then he said he had to use the bathroom.

KATHY: Did you call someone to help him?

JULIA: It was too late. He had gone already. He looked so helpless, so confused. Then, when the nurse came to get him, he smiled at her like he smiled at me and he just walked away with her.

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He just walked right away with her as if he had completely forgotten I was there. And he probably had.

KATHY: I didn't know he had lost control over his bodily functions.

JULIA: Why don't you just say it? He peed all over himself. That's what he did. And I had to stand there and watch. Just watch and there was nothing, not a damned thing I could do. And if it makes me feel this bad, how do you think it makes Mom feel? It's her father, the man who raised her, who taught her about life, who changed her diapers. Now she has to change his. It's just not fair.

KATHY: No, it's not, but it has to be dealt with.

JULIA: Why? Why does it have to be dealt with like this? Do you remember Duchess?

KATHY: The cat?

JULIA: Let's say Grandpa was drowning and so was Duchess the cat. Who would you try to save?

KATHY: Grandpa, of course.

JULIA: SO you love Grandpa more, OK?

KATHY: OK. What's your point?

JULIA: How did Duchess die?

KATHY: We had to put her to sleep because she...

JULIA: We put her to sleep because she got old and sick and "lost control of her bodily functions."

KATHY: Duchess was a cat.

JULIA: SO why is a cat allowed to die with dignity? Why is it humans are forced to live a life of degradation?

KATHY: I said I don't want to talk about this.

JULIA: How do you think Grandpa would feel if he knew what was going on? Do you think he'd want to live like this?

KATHY: I don't know.

JULIA: The hell you don't. Would you want to? I know I wouldn't.

KATHY: You can't say that.

JULIA: Yes, I can. Let me tell you right now, sister dear, that if I should come down with this

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horrible humiliating disease called Alzheimer's, put a pillow over my face and call it a day. There is no way I'd want to live like that.

KATHY: So what do you suggest we do? Smother Grandpa in his bed? Take him out of the home on a trip and leave him on some city street? Maybe throw him in front of an oncoming car. What do you think would be the humane thing?

JULIA: I have no idea. But I do know that this is all wrong. There is nothing right about what he is going through.

KATHY: Well, just thank God our family has enough money to provide a good place for him to live comfortably.

JULIA: And that's another thing. What about people that don't have that kind of money? You didn't go with Mom when she had to finally make the decision to put Grandpa in a home. You should have seen some of those places. Dirty, disgusting, smelly. Some of those old people were walking around with clothes that reeked of urine. Not nearly enough caretakers for the patients. How do you think those families feel who can't afford what we can in the way of care and they have to visit their mothers, fathers, grandparents? And what about us? Grandpa is only sixty-seven years old. He could live for another ten years like this, lingering in and out of consciousness, that dull vacant look in his eyes when he does come around. Financially this could wipe Mom and Dad out.

KATHY: And what if it's hereditary? I'll be honest with you. I have thought about all of this. Maybe that's why I'm so obsessed with doing everything around here. It's my way of not thinking.

JULIA: Thinking about what?

KATHY: About that this might be genetic. Mom could get it, then it could be us. Then what?

JULIA: It won't happen. They'll have a cure by then.

KATHY: You think? I don't. There's tons of money going for cancer and for AIDS. But what about Alzheimer's? You never hear anything about it. There won't be a cure if there is no research.

JULIA: There will be. There has to be.

KATHY: I'm scared all the time. Every time Mom comes in a room and forgets why she came in, it scares me. When she misplaces something, it freaks me out.

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JULIA: Everyone does that. We all forget things. It doesn't mean...

KATHY: I know it doesn't. Intellectually I know. But emotionally...

JULIA: I thought you were the strong one through all this.

KATHY: That's what I try to be. I keep thinking that if I keep busy, if 1 keep things going here in the house and make sure that everyone is taken care of, then maybe nothing will happen.

JULIA: You can't stop things from happening. Like I said, Grandpa is going to die. He should get it over with. And I don't mean that in a cruel way.

KATHY: I know.

JULIA: He should have dropped dead of a heart attack five years ago on the basketball court. That's how he would have liked to go. That's a memory I would have loved. Grandpa's last days being who he was - active, fun, and doing what he loved. Not this shell of a man who just stares into space.

KATHY: It would have been better. Better than this.

JULIA: Yeah. *(they sit for a moment in silence)* I'll do the dishes.

KATHY: OK. Mom should be home pretty soon.

JULIA: I think we should talk to her.

KATHY: Why?

JULIA: Because she probably feels exactly what we are feeling, but is too guilty to talk about it. She needs to be able to talk about it. Like we just did.

KATHY: Yeah. I guess so. Yeah. God, this sucks.

JULIA: It does, doesn't it?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mary Krell-Oishi
Book: Perspectives: Relevant Scenes for Teens, Pgs 167-176
ISBN: 978-156608030
Publisher: Merriwether Publishing, Ltd
Date (Month/Year): March 1997

AWARD HISTORY

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